



HIMANSHU CHAKRAWARTI, 40,
COO, LANDMARK, CHENNAI

To make up for his absence, this workaholic dad often succumbs to his three-year-old daughter Anaya's sometimes unreasonable demands.

“She’s a very sweet child but she knows how to get me to say yes to everything she wants.”

“index patients” are children. Fathers come either because children’s “grades are falling”, or they are getting “difficult to handle”. But in the course of counselling it often appears that it’s the father’s physical or mental absence that’s at the root of the crisis.

The ‘overstretched dad’ is undoubtedly a by-product of modern parenting. “It’s the shifting contours of the post-globalisation family that have created new circumstances for modern parents,” says sociologist Radhika Chopra of Delhi University. Fifty years ago, parenting was simpler for men. As the sole breadwinner, a dad’s responsibilities typically ceased the moment he crossed the threshold of his home. The father was more aloof and

emotionally more detached. The breakdown of the joint family has lessened the father-child distance. The modern father, Chopra points out, “is no longer the patriarch at home”.

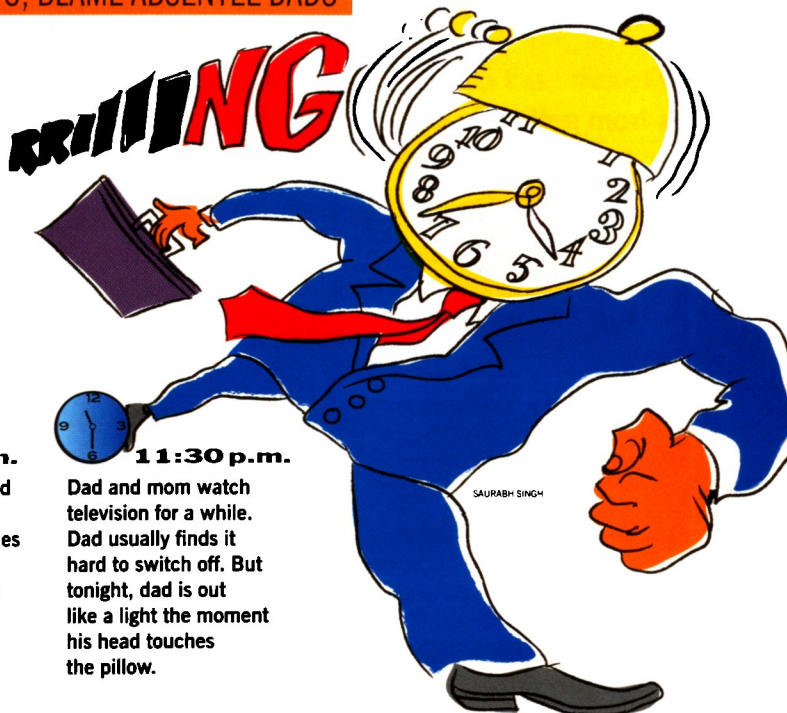
The result is that the idea of the family, the hierarchy within it and the expectations from it are turning upside-down. “Kids don’t seem to hold fathers in awe anymore,” points out Dr Jitendra Nagpal, consultant psychiatrist with VIMHANS, Delhi. “Families are much more child-centric now and children are quick to grasp this.” He has had disgruntled teenagers telling him, “My father is a Sunday Father. I see him only on Sundays.” In a study conducted this year on 1,460 adolescents by VIMHANS, children’s disappointment with fathers comes across clearly: 73 per cent prefer to discuss issues troubling them with friends, and only 13 per cent with parents. They cite an absentee father as the reason for shunning the parental ear. In yet another VIMHANS study in 2005, teachers across the country claimed, 70 to 80 per cent of fathers do not turn up at parent-teacher meetings in schools.

Kolkata’s Harshvardhan Neotia, 45, doesn’t remember the last time he attended a parent-teacher meeting. The industrialist rues that he is proba-

CONFIDE IN FRIENDS, NOT PARENTS; BLAME ABSENTEE DADS

Sivaranjani runs a moody eye over her dad: “Daddy is always in office.”

A gaggle of similarly harried men stream through the consulting room of Dr Aniruddha Deb, a psychiatrist in Kolkata. “Most of them have winning careers, are in their late 30s or 40s, work round the clock, spend long hours in office, are busy on the BlackBerry or the Internet at home, and often on the phone with colleagues across the seas at unearthly hours.” In most cases, the



SAURABH SINGH



9 p.m.

Dad arrives home. About an hour of playtime. Dad cuddles, reads stories, listens and also supervises math homework. He tries to relax and takes his meal.



10 p.m.

Children in bed. Dad brings work home during the week (tries hard to keep the weekends free). He tries to wrap up a project for his forthcoming tour.



11:30 p.m.

Dad and mom watch television for a while. Dad usually finds it hard to switch off. But tonight, dad is out like a light the moment his head touches the pillow.